

LAYER 5 OF 13

HOSTING DEPLOYMENT

Getting Your App Live on the Internet

TIER 1 — SOLOPRENEUR

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Part of the Builder Certification Series

What This Kit Covers

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This kit covers Layer 5: Hosting & Deployment—getting your app live on the internet so other people can actually use it. Right now your app works on your laptop. That's great for building and testing, but your customers can't see it. Hosting is renting space on a computer that's always connected to the internet. Deployment is the process of sending your app to that computer so anyone with the link can open it.

You're not going to manage servers by hand. You're going to use platforms like Vercel, Netlify, or Railway that handle the hard parts for you—you connect your project, click deploy (or it deploys automatically), and your app is live. Your job is to understand what these platforms do, pick the right one for your project, and know how to fix things when a deploy doesn't go as planned.

This kit walks you through three levels. Tier 1 is for someone putting their first app on the internet. Tier 2 is for someone managing multiple environments, custom domains, and team workflows. Tier 3 is for someone running production systems where downtime costs real money. Start at Tier 1. You can always come back for the rest.

Why It Matters

An app that only runs on your laptop isn't a product—it's a homework assignment. The whole point of building something is getting it into the hands of people who need it. Hosting and deployment is the bridge between "I built a thing" and "people are using my thing." Until you cross that bridge, nothing else matters.

Here's the good news: modern hosting platforms have made this dramatically easier than it used to be. The bad news: there are still real decisions to make—like where your environment variables go (hint: never in your code), how to set up a custom domain, and what to do when a deploy breaks at 2am. AI tools can help you deploy, but they won't warn you about the gotchas. This kit teaches you what to watch for.

Certification Tier Map

There are three certification tiers. Each one builds on the one before it. Here's a quick look at who each tier is for and what you'll prove you can do.

Tier

Who It's For

What You Prove

Tier 1

Solo builders shipping their first live app

You can take an app from your laptop to a live URL that anyone can visit, with a custom domain and SSL working correctly.

Tier 2

Growing teams with staging environments and multiple projects

You can manage preview deployments, environment variables across environments, and keep your deploy pipeline reliable as your team grows.

Tier 3

Production systems where uptime and reliability are critical

You can run a deployment operation with zero-downtime deploys, multi-region hosting, rollback procedures, and infrastructure-as-code.

TIER 1 CERTIFICATION GOAL

You can deploy your app to a hosting platform, connect a custom domain, confirm SSL is working, set environment variables safely, and verify your app loads correctly for anyone on the internet.

What You Need to Know

You don't need to manage servers. You need to understand how your app gets from your laptop to a live URL—and what can go wrong along the way.

How hosting platforms work: Platforms like Vercel, Netlify, and Railway connect to your code (usually on GitHub) and automatically build and publish your app every time you push an update. Think of it like Dropbox for your app—you save a file, and it shows up everywhere. The platform handles the server, the internet connection, and keeping things running.

What a domain name is and how DNS works: A domain name is your app's address on the internet—like myapp.com instead of some random string of numbers. DNS (Domain Name System) is like the phone book that translates your domain name into the actual server address. You buy a domain, point it to your hosting platform, and your app gets a real, professional address.

What SSL certificates do: SSL is what puts the padlock icon in the browser and makes your URL start with https instead of http. It encrypts the connection between your user and your app so nobody can spy on the data in between. Most hosting platforms set this up automatically—your job is to verify it's working.

Where environment variables go: Environment variables are secret settings your app needs—like API keys, database passwords, or payment processor credentials. They NEVER go in your code (anyone could read them). They go in your hosting platform's settings panel, where they're encrypted and only your app can access them.

What a build process does: When you deploy, the hosting platform runs a build step that converts your code into something browsers can understand. Sometimes the build fails—usually because of a missing dependency or a typo. You need to know how to read the build log (the error messages) to figure out what went wrong.

Your Toolkit

Your hosting platform does the heavy lifting. Everything else supports getting your app live and keeping it running.

Vercel or Netlify: The two most popular hosting platforms for modern web apps. They connect to your GitHub repo, build your app automatically, and give you a live URL in minutes. Vercel is especially good if your AI tool built your app with Next.js.

A domain registrar (Namecheap, Google Domains, Cloudflare): Where you buy your custom domain name. You'll update the DNS settings there to point to your hosting platform.

GitHub: Where your code lives. Your hosting platform watches your GitHub repo and redeploys every time you push an update. If you're not using GitHub yet, Layer 7 covers this in detail.

Certification Exam Topics

Every exam question is scenario-based. You'll see a real situation and need to identify what's right, what's wrong, or what to do next.

Deployment basics: Your app works on your laptop but shows a blank white page after deploying. What are the first three things you check?

Environment variables: Your app works locally but crashes on the live site with 'API key not found.' Where did you forget to put the key, and where should it go?

Domain setup: You bought a custom domain but visitors still see 'DNS not found.' Can you identify what DNS records need to be configured?

SSL verification: A user reports that your site shows a 'Not Secure' warning. What does this mean and how do you fix it?

Build failures: Your deploy failed and the build log says 'Module not found.' Can you explain what this means in plain language and what to do?

Platform selection: You have a simple marketing site and a complex web app with a database. Should they be on the same hosting platform? Why or why not?

Live site testing: Your app deployed successfully but a page that works locally returns a 404 error on the live site. What could cause this?

Environment safety: A teammate committed an API key directly into the code on GitHub. What's the risk, and what should you do immediately?

Common Pitfalls

These are the mistakes vibecoders make most often with hosting and deployment. No judgment—they're easy to make. But if you recognize any of them in your own workflow, fix them before sitting for the exam.

Putting API keys, database passwords, or secrets directly in your code. Anyone who can see your code can steal your credentials. Environment variables exist for exactly this reason—use them.

Deploying directly to production without testing on a preview or staging environment first. Your users are not your beta testers. Break things in staging, not in front of customers.

Forgetting to set up SSL and leaving your site running on http. Browsers show a scary 'Not Secure' warning, users don't trust it, and their data is exposed in transit.

Buying a domain but never setting up DNS correctly, then wondering why the custom domain shows an error page. DNS changes take time to spread across the internet (up to 48 hours). Plan ahead.

Never setting up deploy notifications, then finding out your site has been down for hours because a customer emailed you. Automated monitoring is not optional.

Treating deployment as a one-time event instead of an ongoing process. Your app will change constantly. Build a deployment workflow you can repeat reliably, not one you barely survived once.

Tier 1 Self-Assessment Checklist

Before you take the exam, run through these questions. Every "no" is something to work on.

Can you deploy your app from your GitHub repo to a hosting platform and get a live, working URL?

Are all of your API keys and secrets stored in environment variables on your hosting platform—not in your code?

Does your live site have SSL working (padlock icon, https in the URL)?

If you have a custom domain, does it point to your hosting platform correctly with no DNS errors?

Do you know how to read a build log and figure out why a deploy failed?

Could you roll back to the previous version of your app if a deploy broke something?

Do you have some form of monitoring that would alert you if your live site went down?

AI Audit Prompt Template

Copy this prompt into your AI coding tool to get a quick health check on your hosting and deployment setup. It checks the same things the certification exam covers.

Review my app's hosting and deployment setup and check the following. For each one, tell me pass or fail with a specific example:

Environment variables: Are all secrets stored in the hosting platform's environment variable settings, with nothing hardcoded in the source code?

SSL and HTTPS: Does the live site load with https and show a valid SSL certificate with no mixed-content warnings?

Build process: Does the build complete without errors, and are there any unnecessary steps slowing it down?

Domain configuration: Is the custom domain properly configured with correct DNS records and no redirect loops?

Deployment pipeline: Is the deploy connected to the GitHub repo with automatic deploys on push, and is there a preview deployment setup for pull requests?

Rollback readiness: Can the site be reverted to the previous deploy with one click or one command, and has this been tested?

Give me an overall score out of 6 and list the top 3 things to fix first.

What's Next

Once you've gone through this kit and can answer "yes" to the self-assessment checklist, you're ready for the Layer 5 certification exam at your target tier.

The best way to prepare: deploy something real. Take one of your projects, put it on Vercel or Netlify, connect a custom domain, and go through the entire process. Pay attention to every error message, every DNS delay, every environment variable you had to set. Those real-world experiences are exactly what the exam tests.

CERTIFICATION PATHWAY

Associate Builder: Pass all 13 layers at Tier 1

Certified Builder: Pass all 13 layers at Tier 1 + Tier 2

MADE Certified: Pass all 39 tier exams + capstone project

Each exam requires 80% to pass. You can retake after a 24-hour cooldown. No rush—take the time to build something real first.

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